

Camsail Annual Chairman's Report for 2020-2021

All our meetings this year were on Zoom (the average attendance was 26, the maximum 34 at the January meeting); it has been a little difficult to know how well these were appreciated. No complaints have been received – so far, but nonetheless we are intending to return to our home ground at the Cambridge Bowls Club for the next season starting on October 13th.

Last season, we began in October with a nostalgic film about the River Deben. This gave us a good idea of the non-navigable upper regions ending around the tidemill in Woodbridge, as well as the more widely known navigable parts to the mouth of the river.

In November we were treated to four excellent and varied presentations by members.

It began with Lottie describing a sail with Derek from Felixstowe Ferry to Falmouth – nonstop (– I seem to remember) in Bernina, their LM 28 sloop. Quite a long passage by two relative newbies, described with much interesting detail, and carried out in a very seamanlike way. I believe that the return journey wisely used the favourable tides during day sails!

This memorable talk was followed by an account of Derek's catastrophic first time sail in a small unlit boat, starting from the south bank of the Thames at night with little equipment. It was a masterful tale of survival of many possible fates, ending up on the rocks on the Essex coast: a captivating story, told in a very straightforward manner.

Jane then reviewed a most interesting collection of nautical books. I have since reread my copy of 'Riddle of the Sands'.

Robert has his fine craft in the Baltic, and he made the islands of the Stockholm Archipelago a must-visit destination.

For our Christmas Zoom, John produced a fun/nautical quiz, which involved us being divided into five 'rooms' to devise our answers. It was a constructive, if complicated, exercise, which did give an opportunity for some nautical chat as well as puzzling the answers.

Camsail's January Zoom was about the Swinburne's journey from south Brittany to the west coast of Spain: wonderful cruising in the Rias, and they left to return just in time to avoid a Biscay storm.

February's gathering started with Graham telling us of the collection of boats in which he explored much of the East Anglian Coast. We were then treated to a very interesting review of Brendan Hall's 'Team Spirit' by Stephen Burgess. This was followed by very different experiences of two members: Charles told of a long, challenging yacht delivery trip from Dubai to Kuwait. He is obviously an extremely experienced and competent yachtsman, who introduced us to places to which few of us have been, let alone sailed. The evening concluded with John's account of meeting a 'Peacefleet' flotilla while sailing in Croatia: Peacefleet brings together disadvantaged youngsters from different ethnic backgrounds in the Balkans, giving them an experience afloat which otherwise they would be very unlikely ever to enjoy.

A film of Antigua Week was shown at our last meeting in March. This was made about Don Street and his engineless wooden yawl Iolaire. Much of the film was shot from on board the boat during the course of six races between a wide selection of classic racing yachts. Midweek was a 'harbour day', when all sorts of silly water games were played with much gusto by almost everyone, with tightropes, dinghies, balloons and many other unimaginable props, and rum punch in plenty. We still have the DVD if anyone would like to borrow it.

This has been a very different year, and I think we have had an interesting and pretty varied programme of meetings, some of which have possibly had more 'attending' than at our venue. I would like to give a big thank you to those of you who took the trouble and opportunity to contribute to the meetings. I believe that having a higher proportion of our meeting time devoted to members' talks and pictures is a 'good thing' (2020 and all that)! Finally, on behalf of the Camsail committee and all members, I must give my heartiest thanks to our invaluable Secretary, John, without whom there would have been no programme to recount for this year.